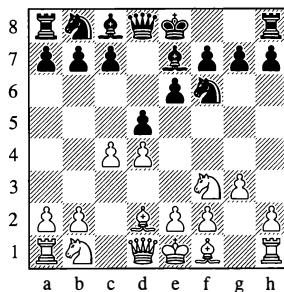


Chapter 13

Catalan 4...♘b4†



Introduction to 5...♗e7

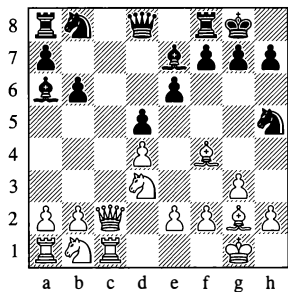
Variation Index

1.d4 ♘f6 2.c4 e6 3.g3 d5 4.♘f3 ♗b4† 5.♗d2 ♗e7

6.♗g2 0-0 7.0-0

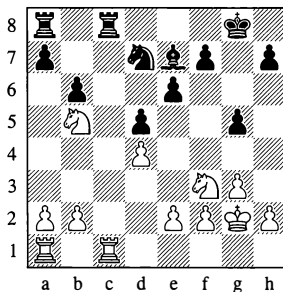
A) 7...dxc4?!	182
B) 7...♘bd7	184
C) 7...c6 8.♖c2 b6 9.♗f4	186
C1) 9...♗a6 10.cxd5 cxd5 11.♖c1! ♘bd7 12.♘c3	186
C11) 12...♘h5	188
C12) 12...b5	189
C2) 9...♗b7 10.♖d1	190
C21) 10...♘h5	191
C22) 10...♘a6	194

C1) note to 11...♘bd7



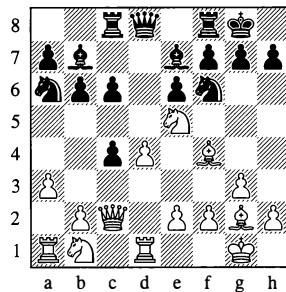
16.♗c7!N

C11) after 17...g5



18.♘c7!N

C22) after 12...dxc4

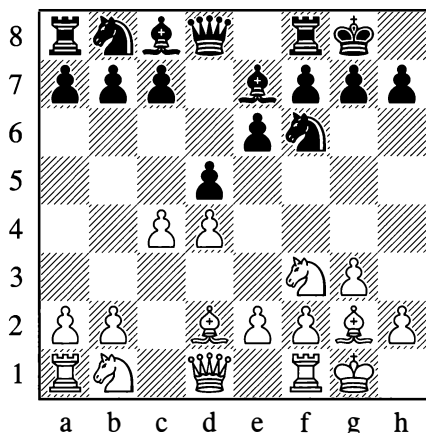


13.♖xc4!N

1.d4 ♘f6 2.c4 e6 3.g3 d5 4.♘f3 ♙b4† 5.♙d2
♙e7 6.♙g2 0–0

If Black plays something else, then the game will just continue along similar lines as the variations below, with a probable transposition after both sides castle.

7.0–0



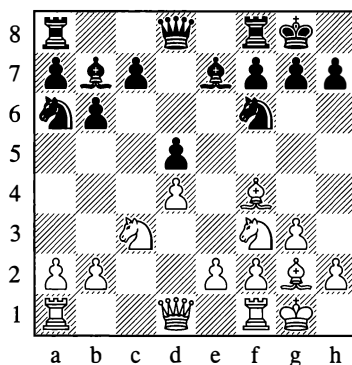
This is the main tabiya for the entire 4...♙b4† variation. Black's three most popular moves are A) 7...dxc4?!, B) 7...♘bd7 and C) 7...c6.

Black's most popular system involves ...c6 and ...♘bd7, and it will be discussed in detail in the next chapter. Needless to say, variations B and C of this chapter will cover the various possibilities involving one move but not the other.

7...b6 8.cxd5 gives Black a choice:

a) 8...♘xd5 is unusual but worth a quick look: 9.e4 ♘f6 10.♘c3 ♙b7 11.♙e1 ♘bd7 Now I like 12.♙c2N, intending to meet 12...c5 with 13.d5! exd5 14.exd5 when the d5-pawn is untouchable due to some simple tactics: 14...♘xd5? 15.♘xd5 ♙xd5 16.♙xe7! ♙xe7 17.♘g5 and White wins.

b) 8...exd5 9.♘c3 ♙b7 10.♙f4 ♘a6 (10...♘bd7 11.♙c2 would transpose to variation B12 of Chapter 15, although via this move order 11.♙c1! looks more accurate, in order to keep the option of developing the queen to a more active square such as a4 or b3.)



This position has occurred in hundreds of games (mostly via a Queen's Indian move order), and it would take a few pages to analyse it in detail. I do not feel it is necessary to do so, as it has fallen out of fashion from Black's perspective, and the chances of reaching it via a Catalan are minimal. I will just mention that a logical continuation is 11.♙c1 c5 12.♘e5! ♘c7 13.dxc5 bxc5 14.♙a4 ♘e6 15.♙fd1, when White has strong pressure against the hanging pawns and has achieved a heavy plus score.

7...♘c6

This can be mentioned as a playable sideline for Black, but my feeling is that White will always be better with the knight on this square. Here are a few illustrative lines.

8.♙c2 ♘e4 9.♙d1

I find this to be the most flexible set-up for White.

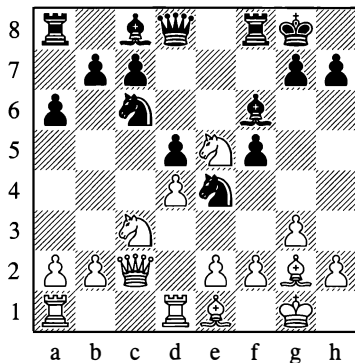
9...f5

9...a5 10.♘c3 f5 11.a3 ♙f6 12.e3 ♘h8 13.♙ac1 ♘e7 14.♘e2 c6 15.♘f4 ♙d7 16.♙e1 ♘g6 17.♘d3 gave White an excellent game in Sjugirov – Fressinet, Moscow 2013.

10.♘c3 ♙f6 11.♙e1 a6 12.cxd5!?

There was nothing wrong with maintaining the pressure with the simple 12.♖ac1N±.
12...exd5 13.♘e5

The point behind White's trade in the centre.



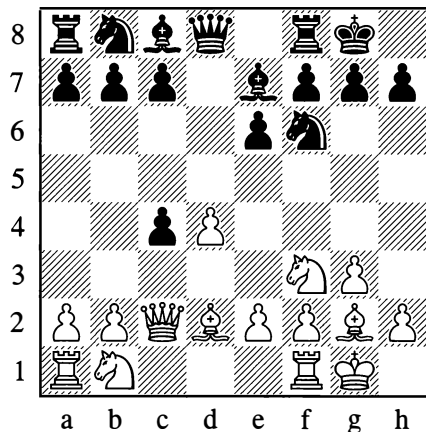
13...♘e7 14.♖ac1 c6 15.♗b3 ♘h8

Now in El Debs – Korobov, Moscow 2011,
White should have continued:

16.♘xe4!N fxe4 17.♙b4

Followed by f2-f3, with a clear advantage.

A) 7...dxc4?! 8.♗c2



There is little sense in this line for Black, as he simply has an inferior version of the 4...♙e7 variation with the white bishop on d2 instead of c1, which is a useful extra tempo.

8...a6

8...♙d7 9.♗xc4 ♙c6 10.♘c3 ♘e4 11.♖fd1

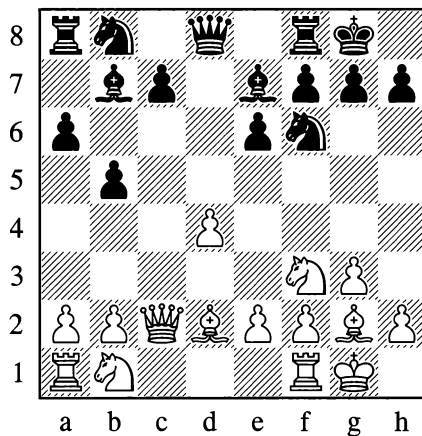
also gives White easy play, for instance: 11...♘xc3 12.bxc3 (It is also worth considering 12.♗xc3 ♘d7 13.♖ac1 ♘f6 14.♗a5± with the better game) 12...♗d5 13.♗b3 ♗xb3 14.axb3 ♙d5 15.c4 ♙e4 16.♘e5 ♙xg2 17.♘xg2 White reached a clearly favourable endgame in Miroshnichenko – Peschel, Plovdiv 2010.

9.♗xc4

9.a4 is also playable, but in that case it is not so clear if the bishop will be useful on d2. The text move is a more principled way to utilize the extra tempo.

9...b5 10.♗c2 ♙b7

If you skip ahead to Chapter 16, you will see that I am no longer advocating this position for White against the 4...♙e7 variation with ...dxc4. However, with White to move instead of Black, it is a totally different story.



11.♖c1

This is the most natural way to take advantage of the free tempo.

11...♙d6

11...♘c6 12.e3 reaches a known position with the free move ♖f1-c1 for White. I don't see much point in analysing this in detail here, but if you have a copy of *GM 1* on your shelf,

you can find the position without the free tempo analysed from page 208.

12.♙g5 ♖bd7 13.♙xf6!?

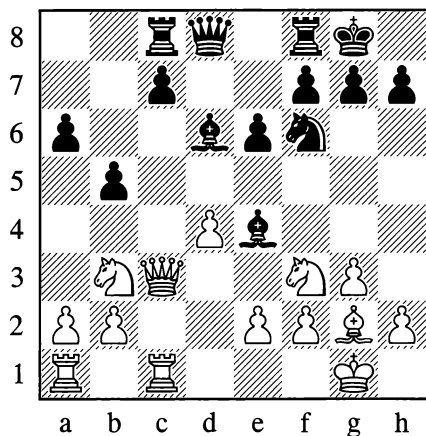
There are other ways to fight for the advantage, but this direct approach still seems fine.

13...♖xf6

The natural 13...♖xf6 runs into 14.♖g5! (14.♖e5 ♖xe5! 15.♙xb7 ♖a7∞ is not so clear) 14...♖xg5 15.♙xb7 ♖ab8 16.♙c6 ♖f6 17.♖d2± when White has prevented the ...c5-advance and is in full control.

14.♖bd2 ♖c8 15.♖b3 ♙e4 16.♖c3

Here too, White has succeeded in stopping ...c5, and his chances are better. There is certainly no need to memorize any more than this, and the following examples are just included for instructive purposes.

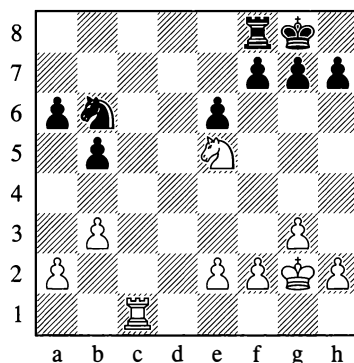


16...♙d5

16...♖d5 17.♖a5 ♙b4?! (17...♖b6N is better, but still does not bring much relief after 18.♖fd2 ♙xg2 19.♖xg2±) 18.♖xa6 c6 19.♖e5 ♙xg2 20.♖xg2 ♖e7 21.e4± White was simply a pawn up in Hoffmann – Berger, Germany 2009.

Another game continued: 16...♖e7 17.♖c5

(17.♖e5!? is a worthy alternative) 17...♙xc5 18.♖xc5 ♖xc5 19.♖xc5 ♖d7 20.♖c3 c5 21.dxc5 ♖xc5 22.♖xc5 ♖xc5 23.♖c1 Even after carrying out ...c5, Black experiences definite problems. 23...♖a4 24.b3 ♖b6 25.♖e5 ♙xg2 26.♖xg2



Despite the simplification, the endgame was unpleasant for Black in Larsen – Cu. Hansen, Copenhagen 1985. It is worth mentioning that the further simplifying 26...♖c8N 27.♖xc8† ♖xc8 28.♖f3 f6 29.♖c6 ♖f7 30.♖e4 reaches a knight endgame that will be difficult, perhaps even impossible, for Black to hold.

17.♖fd2 ♙xg2 18.♖xg2 ♖d5

18...b4? is a clear positional mistake that renders Black's queenside highly vulnerable. 19.♖c6 e5 20.dxe5 ♙xe5 21.♖c4± White had a strategically winning position in Khalifman – Tissir, Shenyang 2000.

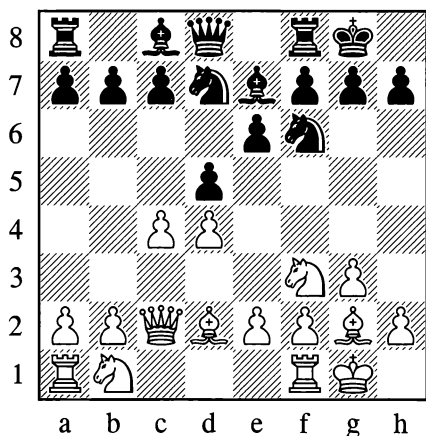
18...c6N looks like the lesser evil, although White is obviously better after 19.♖f3±, as pointed out in *GM 1*.

19.♖c6 ♖b4 20.♖f3 f5 21.a3 ♖d5 22.♖c5 ♖e7 23.♖c2 ♖a8 24.♖ac1 ♖f6 25.e3±

White's positional advantage was beyond any doubt in Quaresma – Salvador Marques, corr. 2011.

B) 7...♘bd7 8.♖c2

The great majority of games from this position have continued with 8...c6, transposing to the next chapter. In this section I will mention a few other possibilities.



8...♗e4

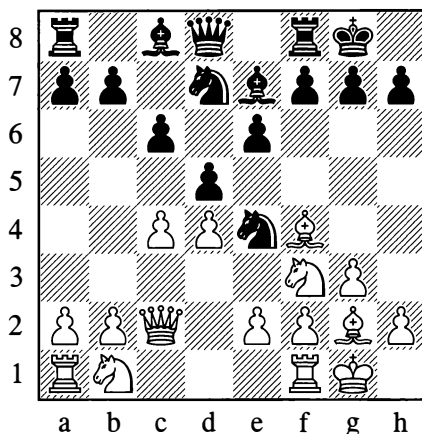
Black is intending to play in the spirit of the Stonewall, having avoided the thematic plan of b2-b3 and ♙a3.

8...b6 can be dealt with quickly. (There is a reason why most players prefer to preface this move with ...c6.) 9.cxd5! ♗xd5 (9...exd5 10.♙f4 c5 11.♗c3 ♙b7 transposes to variation B12 of Chapter 15, with one extra move having been played – see page 234.) The text move is an independent alternative, but it is not much of an equalizing attempt. The simplest answer is 10.e4N ♗b4 11.♙xb4 ♙xb4 12.a3 ♙e7 13.♗c3 ♙b7 14.♖ad1 and White has a pleasant edge thanks to his central superiority.

9.♙f4 c6

I was surprised to find well over a hundred games from this position, including Game 9 of the Moscow 1963 World Championship match, in which Botvinnik held with Black against Petrosian. Black's idea is to establish a

Stonewall set-up with ...f5 and quite possibly ...g5.



10.♗fd2

This looks like the best way to fight for an advantage.

Initially I was optimistic about the natural 10.♗c3, but I noticed the strong reply: 10...g5! (10...f5 gave White time to arrange his pieces optimally with 11.♖ad1 g5 12.♙c1 ♖h8 13.♗e1± in Levin – Karpman, Lvov 1988) 11.♙c1 f5 12.b3 ♙f6 13.♙b2 ♖e7 (Botvinnik put his bishop on g7 instead, but the text move is more accurate) 14.e3 ♖g7 Black was solid enough in Rogers – Papaioannou, Agios Nikolaos 1995.

10...♗xd2

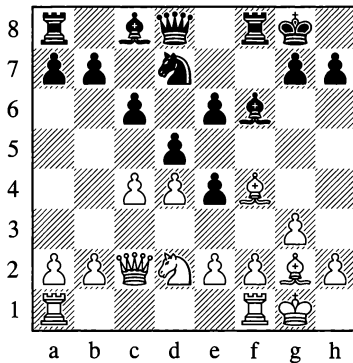
Worse is:

10...f5?! 11.♗xe4! fxe4 12.♗d2

White has the simple plan of f2-f3, breaking up Black's pawn chain and opening a path towards the weak e6-pawn.

12...♙f6

12...♙g5 13.♙xg5 ♖xg5 14.♖c3 ♗f6 15.f3 exf3 16.♗xf3 ♖h5 17.♗e5!± gave White a clear positional advantage in Tukmakov – Boric, Pula 2000.



13.♙d6

13.♙ad1!? has also been played, and looks like an interesting alternative.

13...♙f7 14.e3 e5

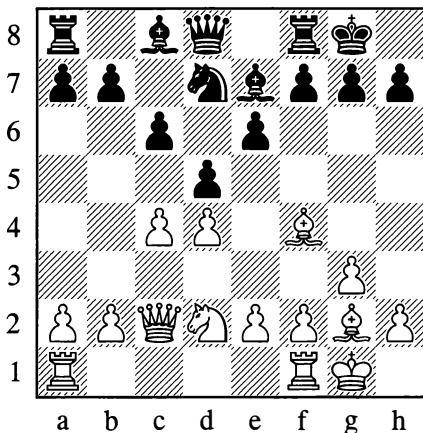
It is understandable that Black wanted to take action before f2-f3 was played, but White is much better suited to deal with the opening of the centre.

15.♙b3 exd4 16.cxd5 cxd5 17.♙xd5 ♖b6 18.♙c5±

Black's pawn on e4 was doomed in Kaidanov – Benjamin, Long Beach 1993.

11.♘xd2

If White is allowed to carry out the e2-e4 advance he will have an obvious advantage, which explains Black's next couple of moves.



11...g5 12.♙e3 f5 13.f3 ♙f7

Black should not rush with 13...f4?!, when 14.♙f2 ♘f6 15.e4 gave White a clear advantage in the old game Fine – Steiner, Washington (2) 1944.

13...♙d6 14.♙f2 ♘f6 15.e4

White should not delay this move, otherwise ...g4 might prevent it.

15...fxe4

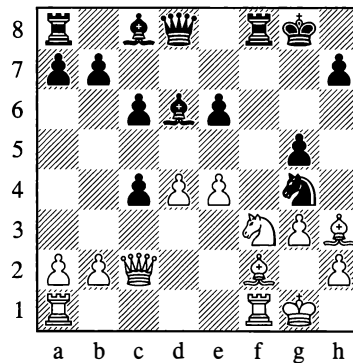
15...dxe4 16.fxe4 ♘g4 leads to a different type of structure, but after 17.♘f3! f4 18.e5 ♙c7 19.gxf4 ♙xf4 20.♙g3 White retains an obvious advantage.

16.fxe4 ♘g4 17.♘f3

In *GM 1* I suggested something else, but actually the game continuation is fine for the next few moves.

17...dxc4 18.♙h3!

An excellent move by Tukmakov.



18...♘xf2 19.♙xf2 b5 20.e5!N

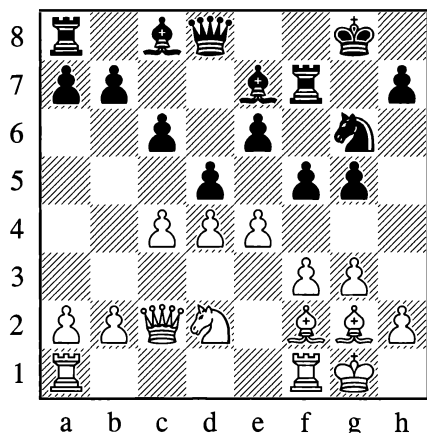
It is important to insert this move. In Tukmakov – Cifuentes Parada, Wijk aan Zee 1992, White played 20.♙af1?! instead, when Black missed the opportunity to complicate the game with 20...e5!N.

20...♙e7 21.♙af1

White has a dangerous initiative on the kingside.

14.♙f2 ♘f8 15.e4 ♘g6

This position occurred in Lautier – Bareev, Dortmund 1995. Now White has an interesting idea at his disposal.

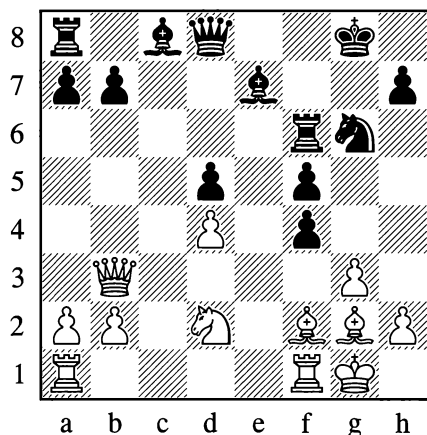


16.exf5 N exf5 17.cxd5 cxd5 18.f4! gxf4
19.♙b3

White has changed the character of the position to good effect, as the following short lines demonstrate.

19...♙f6

Black cannot defend the pawn with 19...♙e6, as after 20.♙ae1 ♙d7 21.♙xe6! ♙xe6 22.♙xd5 ♙f6 23.♙xb7± White emerges with an extra pawn.



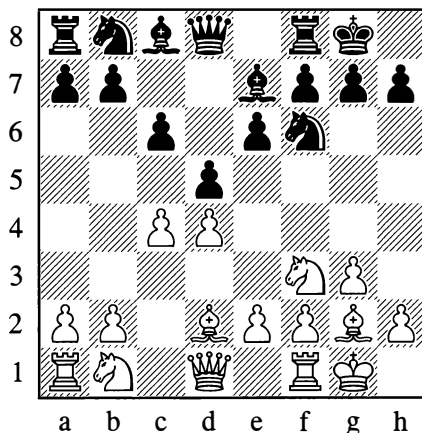
20.♙xd5† ♙g7 21.♙g2! ♙b6 22.♙c2

22.♙f3 ♙xb2 23.♙c4 ♙b4 24.♙c3∞ is also interesting, as the vulnerability of Black's rook gives White good compensation.

22...♙d7 23.♙c4 ♙c8 24.b3

White's chances seem preferable, as Black's king is slightly exposed.

C) 7...c6



This is Black's first choice by a long way. Let me remind you that ...♙bd7 on the next move or two will transpose to the next chapter, so here we will only deal with lines where Black delays the knight's development for longer.

8.♙c2

This is the most accurate move order. 8.♙f4 allows Black the additional option of 8...dxc4, when 9.♙e5 b5 10.♙xc6 ♙xc6 11.♙xc6 ♙d7 12.♙xa8 ♙xa8 led to a fascinating game in Anand – Topalov, Sofia (7) 2010.

8...b6 9.♙f4

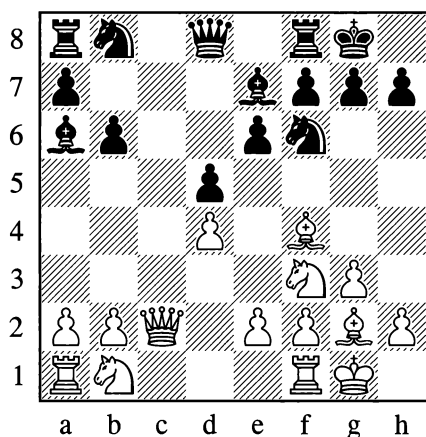
Now Black's two main possibilities are C1) 9...♙a6 and C2) 9...♙b7.

C1) 9...♙a6 10.cxd5!?

Previously I recommended 10.b3, but I later realized that this would be an interesting moment to make the central exchange.

10...cxd5

10...♙xd5 11.♙d1 ♙d7 12.♙c3 ♙c8 13.♙e5 transposes to variation C131 of the next chapter on page 209.



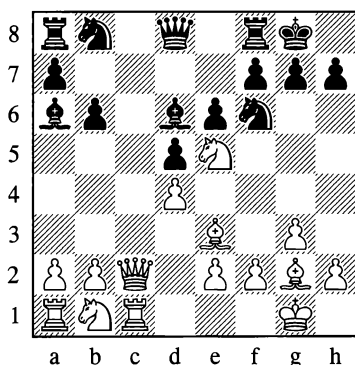
11.♙c1!

This is the key to White's idea. The point is that it will not be easy for Black to develop his queenside.

11...♙bd7

This has been by far the most popular continuation, but I considered some other possibilities.

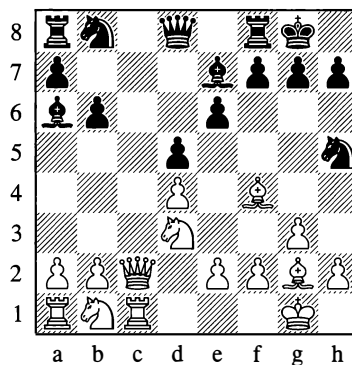
11...♙d6 12.♙e5! This strong move has been played in a computer game. (After 12.♙c3 ♗c6 13.♙a4 ♙b7 Black had no problems in Sengupta – Vaibhav, New Delhi 2010) 12...♙h5 13.♙e3 ♙f6 (I also considered the logical 13...♙d7 14.f4 ♙hf6 15.♙c3 ♙c8 16.♙b3 ♙e7 17.♙b5 ♙xb5 18.♙xb5 ♙b8 19.a4± and White retains definite pressure)



14.♙c3 ♙xe5 15.dxe5 ♙g4 16.♙d4 ♙c6

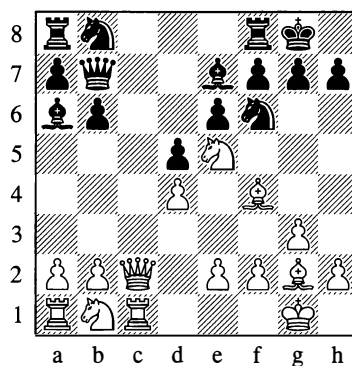
17.♙a4 ♙b7 18.f4 ♙xd4 19.♙xd4 ♙h6 20.♙h3! White's positional advantage was clear in Komodo – Spike, Internet 2012.

11...♙h5 12.♙e3 (After 12.♙c7 ♙c8 13.e4 dxe4 14.♙xe4 ♙b7 15.♙e3 ♙e8 White fails to achieve anything significant) 12...♙f6 13.♙e5 ♙fd7 14.♙d3 ♙f6 15.♙f4 ♙h5 Again we have a computer game, Naum – Gull, Internet 2014, but this time I have an improvement:



16.♙c7!N ♙c8 17.♙c3! The bishop is untouchable, and after 17...♙d7 18.♙f4 ♙hf6 19.♙a4 ♙c4 20.b3 ♙xc7 21.bxc4± White is clearly better.

11...♙d7 12.♙e5 ♙b7



13.♙d1N

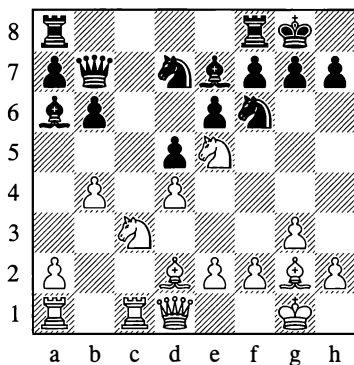
This is my idea to improve on 13.♙c7 ♙xc7 14.♙xc7 ♙d6 15.♙c2 ♙h5, when Black equalized without much difficulty in Aronian – Topalov, Nice (rapid) 2009.

13...♘h5

After 13...♙d6 White can develop his play with 14.♘c3 ♘bd7 15.a3 followed by b2-b4.

14.♙d2 ♘f6 15.♘c3 ♘bd7 16.b4!

Once Black's queen has landed on b7, advancing the pawn to b5 is White's main idea.



16...♙xb4

This is more or less forced, as 16...b5 17.a4 is too dangerous for Black.

17.♘xd5 ♘xd5 18.♙xb4±

White will enjoy long-term pressure, thanks to his bishop pair.

12.♘c3

At this point Black's two main tries are C11)

12...♘h5 and C12) 12...b5.

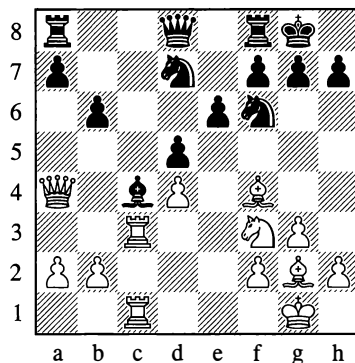
12...♙c8 has done okay for Black in a few games, but I found a promising new idea in 13.♙b3!N, trying to exploit the unsafe position of Black's queen. 13...♙b7 14.e4! ♙c4 (The e4-pawn appears to be untouchable: 14...dxe4? 15.♘g5 and 14...♘xe4? 15.♘xe4 dxe4 16.♘d2 are both bad for Black) 15.♙d1 dxe4 16.♘xe4 White has a dangerous initiative.

12...♙b4 13.♙a4!

This interesting pawn sacrifice seems more promising than 13.♙f1, when 13...♙c8 14.♙a4 ♙xc3 15.bxc3 ♙c4 16.♘d2 ♘e4 was unclear in Wang Yue – Lysyj, Zürich 2010.

13...♙xc3 14.♙xc3 ♙xe2 15.♙ac1 ♙c4

Originally I found White's 13th move as a novelty, but then it was played in Laxman – Vidit, Kottayam 2014. The next move of my prior analysis improves on that game.



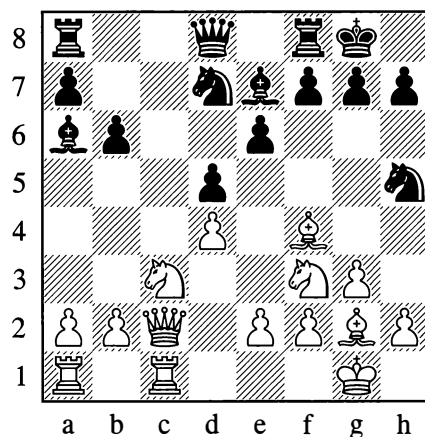
16.♘d2N b5 17.♙d1 ♘b6 18.♙c2!

18.b3 b4 19.♙c2 ♙d3 20.♙c7 ♘e8 is less convincing.

18...b4 19.♙e1 ♙d3 20.♙c6

White's compensation is beyond any doubts.

C11) 12...♘h5



13.♙a4! ♘xf4

13...♙b7 runs into the thematic 14.♙c7!. When this idea works, Black will usually be in trouble, as his knight will be left misplaced on h5. 14...♙e8 15.♙b3 ♘b8 This position was reached in Kuzubov – Sivuk, Alushta 2011,

and now the simple 16.a4N ♖c6 17.a5 would have won a pawn.

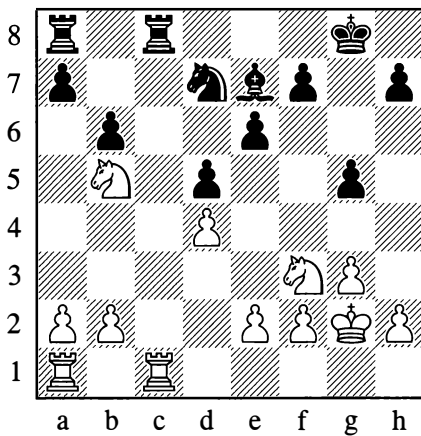
14.♙xa6 ♖xg2 15.♙xg2 ♙c8 16.♙xc8 ♙fxc8 17.♖b5!

The arising endgame is rather unpleasant for Black.

17...g5

After 17...♙xc1 18.♙xc1 a6 19.♙c7 axb5 20.♙xd7 ♖f8 21.a3 White went on to convert his advantage in Tkachiev – Pavlidis, Skopje 2014.

The text move seems to be Black's best resource, and it was played in Avrukh – Mitkov, Chicago 2014.



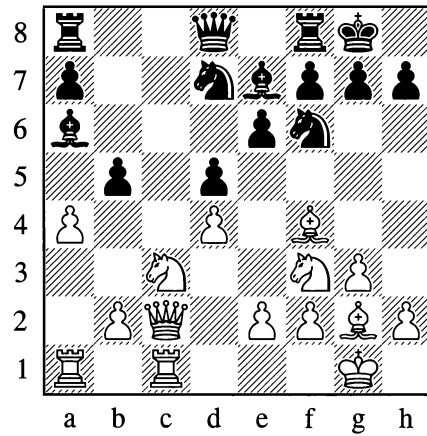
18.♖c7!N

In the game I chose 18.♖e1, when my opponent missed a chance to relieve the pressure: 18...♙xc1N 19.♙xc1 a6 20.♖c7 (20.♙c7 axb5 21.♙xd7 ♙f6 is not dangerous for Black) 20...♙a7 21.♖e8 I was pinning my hopes on this unexpected resource, but the engine immediately points out the amazing 21...♖c5!!, when Black traps the knight and simplifies into a drawish endgame.

18...♙ab8 19.a4±

White keeps a risk-free edge.

C12) 12...b5 13.a4!

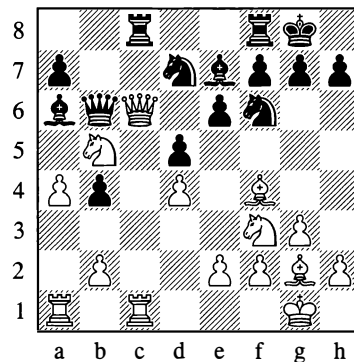


It goes without saying that this is the only way for White to fight for the advantage. In fact, no other moves have even been tested.

13...♙b6

13...bxa4? 14.♙xa4 ♙b7 15.♖b5 already puts Black in big trouble. 15...♖b6 16.♙b3 ♖e8 was played in Beckhuis – Sprenger, Germany 2006, and now 17.♖c7 ♖xc7 18.♙xc7+ would have won material.

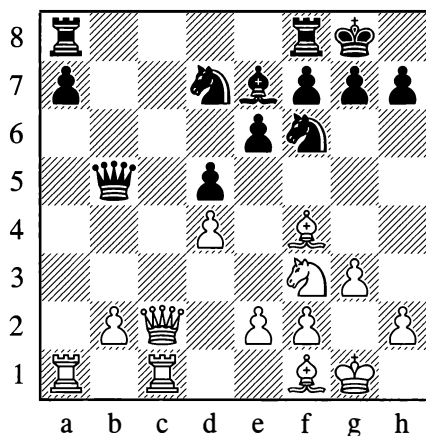
13...b4 14.♖b5 is also difficult for Black. A good example is: 14...♙b6 15.♙c6 ♙ac8



16.♖c7! ♙xc6 17.♙xc6 ♙b7 18.♙cc1 ♙a8 19.♖d6 ♖xd6 20.♖xd6 ♙a6 21.e3+ White had serious pressure thanks to his domination over the c-file in Sychevsky – Bortnyk, Mukachevo 2013.

14.axb5 ♙xb5 15.♘xb5 ♜xb5 16.♙f1

With the two bishops and more active rooks, White can exert lasting pressure without any risk. The following lines show the most accurate ways of achieving this.

**16...a5**

16...♙b7 can be met by 17.♜c6N ♜xc6 18.♙xc6 a5 19.♙c7 with the prospect of long-term torture for Black.

16...♙b6 17.♙c7 ♙b7 18.e3 a6 19.♜c6 ♜xc6 20.♙xc6 ♘b8 occurred in Lim – Myo, Nay Pyi Taw 2013, and now the obvious 21.♙b6N ♙c8 22.♙b7 would have left White with a clear plus.

17.e3 ♙b7

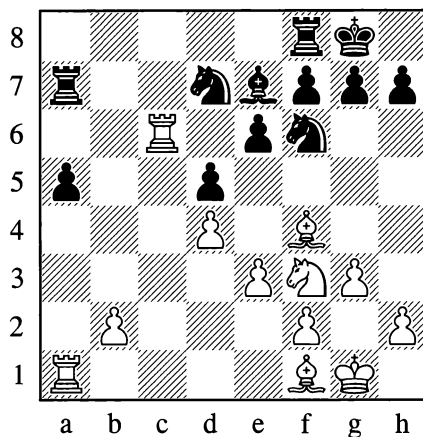
17...♙b4 is well met by 18.♘e1! followed by ♘d3.

18.♜c6 ♜xc6 19.♙xc6 ♙a7

This is apparently the best way to defend Black's inferior position.

The stem game continued: 19...a4 20.♙b5 a3 21.bxa3 ♙xa3 (21...♙xa3N 22.♙xa3 ♙xa3 23.♙a6 ♙b4 24.g4!±) 22.♙c7 Surprisingly, trading the last of the queenside pawns has not solved Black's problems, as White's bishop pair and more active pieces give him ongoing pressure. 22...♘b6 23.♙b7 ♘c4 24.♙xc4 dxc4

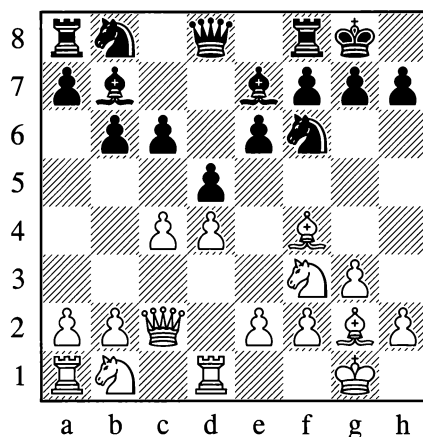
25.♙c7 White won a pawn and eventually the game in Gelfand – Wang Hao, London 2012.

**20.♙b5N**

20.♙c7 ♙fa8 did not achieve much in Vivante-Sowter – Lautenbach, corr. 2012.

20...♙fa8 21.♙a4

Black is doomed to passive defence.

C2) 9...♙b7 10.♙d1

I consider this White's most flexible move. Now Black's main continuation is 10...♘bd7, which transposes to variation C2 of the next chapter on page 214. In the rest of this chapter we will focus on C21) 10...♘h5 and C22) 10...♘a6.

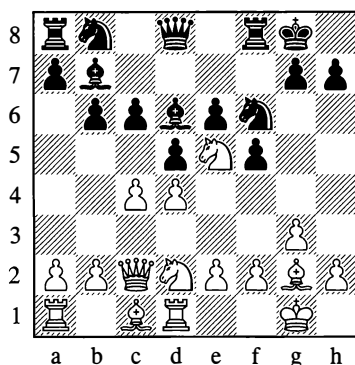
10...a5 is sometimes a useful move in similar positions, but I do not see much point in it here. 11.♘c3 ♘a6 (11...dxc4 12.♘e5 ♘d5 13.♘xc4 ♘xf4 14.gxf4 gives Black an inferior version of a thematic type of position, as he has wasted a tempo and weakened his queenside with ...a5.) 12.a3! Simply restricting the knight. 12...dxc4 13.♘e5 ♘d5 14.♘xc4 ♘xf4 15.gxf4 ♖c7 16.e3 g6 17.♙ac1 ♗fd8 18.♘e5 White was clearly better in Verduyn – Roeder, Vlissingen 2010.

C21) 10...♘h5 11.♙c1

This is a better square than d2; the bishop avoids blocking the d1-rook, and may be developed on b2 later.

11...♘f6

11...f5 is always an option when the knight has moved from f6, but it fails to equalize here. 12.♘e5 ♙d6 (12...♘d7N allows 13.cxd5 cxd5 14.♘c6± when White eliminates one of the bishops) 13.♘d2 ♘f6



14.♘d3N (In the only game White prematurely released the central tension with 14.cxd5, and after 14...cxd5 15.♘df3 ♘e4 he failed to achieve anything in Pashikian – Jojua, Istanbul 2007) 14...♘bd7 15.b4!± White has a promising position and is already getting active on the queenside.

Black has also tried:

11...♘d7 12.♘c3

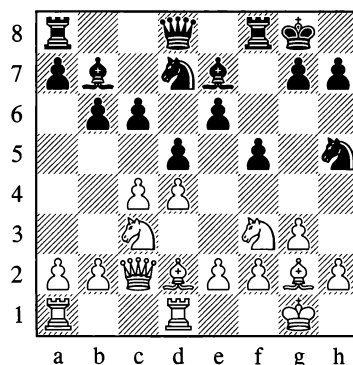
In *GM 1* I recommended 12.♘e5, but it is hard to say if White has much of an advantage after the cool-headed 12...♘hf6. Still, after 13.cxd5 cxd5 14.♘c6 ♙xc6 15.♗xc6 ♙c8 16.♗b5 I had the two bishops and eventually won in Avrukh – Nisipeanu, Germany 2014, so you may wish to keep this as a playable alternative.

12...f5

12...♘hf6 transposes to 11...♘f6 12.♘c3 ♘bd7, as covered in the main line below.

13.♙d2!?

This is an unusual way of developing against the Stonewall, and it looks especially odd after retreating the bishop to c1 a few moves ago. The surprising point is that Black is short of useful developing moves. This position has occurred only once with Black to move, in a computer game.



13...♗e8

13...♘hf6? is not possible in view of 14.♘g5!.

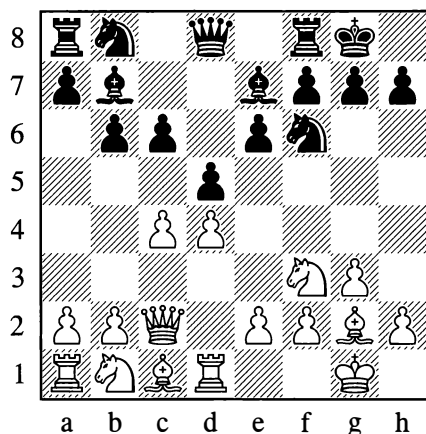
13...♙c8 is met by 14.♗a4! a6 15.♗b3 when the b6-pawn may become a target in some lines.

14.♙ac1 dxc4

This ruins Black's pawn structure and gives White a lot of compensation.

15.♘e5! ♘xe5 16.dxe5 ♗c8 17.♙f3 g6 18.♙h6 ♗f7 19.♙d2 b5 20.♙cd1

White had plenty of play for the pawn in Houdini 4 – Stockfish, Internet 2013.



12.♙c3 ♙bd7

12...♙a6 should be met by: 13.b3 (13.a3 dxc4 was not so clear in Gupta – Tiviakov, Bhubaneswar 2009) 13...c5 (White should not worry about 13...♙b4, as 14.♞b1 c5 15.dxc5 bxc5 16.a3 ♙c6 17.cxd5 ♙xd5 18.♙b2± leaves him with a pleasant edge) 14.dxc5 bxc5 This was Bereolos – Scekic, Schaumburg 2006, and now my preference would be 15.a3N ♞c8 16.e3± with a pleasant edge.

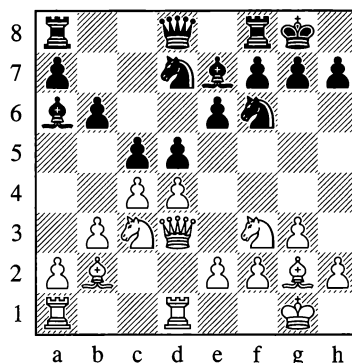
13.b3 ♞c8

This has been by far the most common move, but it may not be best.

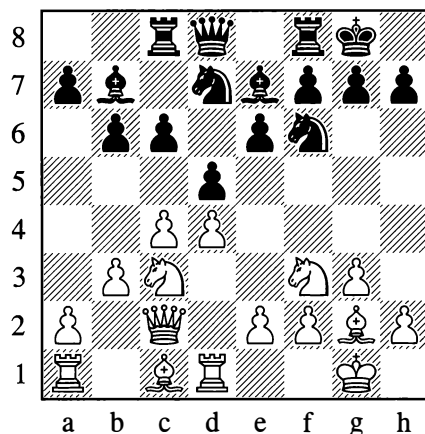
13...c5 gives White a favourable version of a Queen's Indian position: 14.cxd5 ♙xd5 15.♙xd5 exd5 16.♙b2 ♞c8 17.dxc5! ♙xc5 (After 17...bxc5 18.♙e1 ♙b6 19.a4 White's pressure is obvious) 18.♙h3 ♙e6 19.♞d2± White had a pleasant game playing against the IQP in Postny – Nigalidze, Yerevan 2014.

13...♙a6!? is quite interesting, despite the loss of a tempo with the bishop. 14.♞d3!?N Usually I am not a big fan of this move, but in this position it looks sensible, as it prevents Black's main idea of ...b5. (In a recent game

Black easily solved his opening problems after 14.♙d2 b5! 15.e4 dxc4 16.bxc4 bxc4 17.♙a4 c5 with a double-edged game, Chandra – Boros, Saint Louis 2014) 14...c5 15.♙b2 We have reached a typically tense Catalan middlegame position. A brief illustrative line is:



15...♞c8 16.♙b5! ♙xb5 17.cxb5 White's bishop pair should give him a long-term edge. An important point is that 17...c4 18.bxc4 ♞xc4 19.♞dc1 is clearly in White's favour.



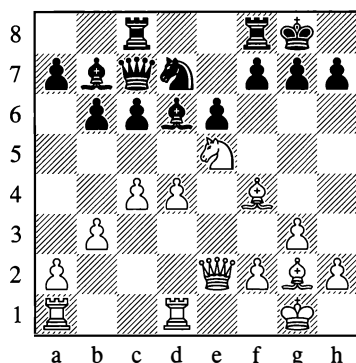
14.e4

This should lead to a comfortable advantage.

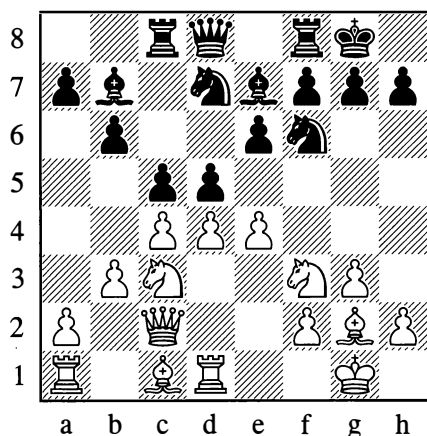
14...c5

14...dxe4 15.♙xe4 ♙xe4 16.♞xe4 As usually happens in this type of Catalan position, if Black is unable to carry out ...c6-c5 right away,

he will probably fall into trouble. 16...♘f6 (Another good example continued: 16...h6 17.♙f4 ♙a8 18.♞e2 ♞c8 19.♞d3 White is now ready to meet ...c5 with d4-d5. 19...♘f6 20.♞ad1 ♞d8 21.♘e5 White was clearly better in Paetz – Ushenina, Konya 2012.) 17.♞e2 ♞c7 18.♙f4 ♙d6 19.♘e5 ♘d7



20.c5! A thematic idea, blocking Black's light-squared bishop. 20...♙e5 21.♙xe5 ♘xe5 22.dxe5 bxc5 23.♞d6 ♞cd8 24.♞ad1 White had a clear advantage in Mamrukov – Tanda, email 2011.



15.exd5!

In 2007 I played 15.dxc5 and eventually won a nice game against Neverov, but Black's play can be improved. Nowadays I consider the text move a more convincing route to an advantage.

15...exd5 16.♙b2

White's active pieces give him excellent chances, despite the symmetrical pawn structure. It is worth following the game for a few more moves.

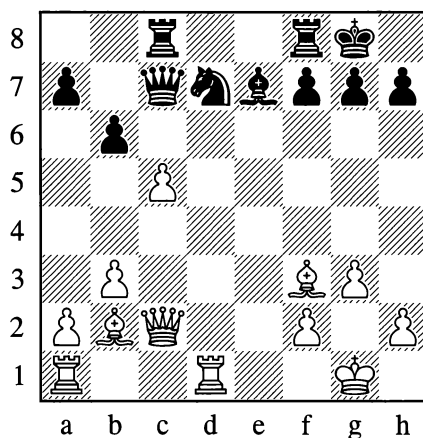
16...♞c7

16...dxc4 runs into 17.d5! cxb3 18.axb3+ and White threatens both d5-d6 and ♞xa7.

17.cxd5 ♘xd5 18.♘xd5 ♙xd5 19.dxc5

Black is forced to give up his light-squared bishop.

19...♙xf3 20.♙xf3



20...♞xc5N

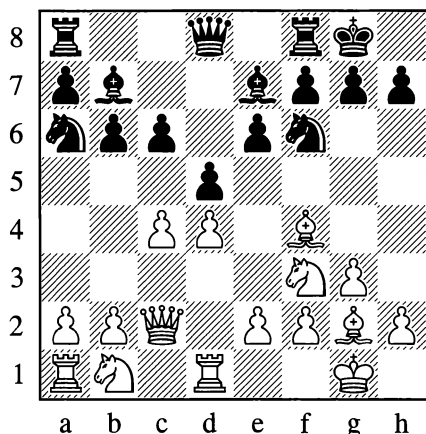
Black would have to do something to improve on 20...♙xc5? 21.♞f5! ♘b8 22.♙e4 when he could already have resigned in De Boer – Tindall, Hoogeveen 1997.

20...♘xc5N 21.♙d5 gives White a clear positional plus.

21.♞e2 ♙f6 22.♞ac1 ♞ce8 23.♞xc5 ♞xe2 24.♙xe2 ♘xc5 25.♙xf6 gxf6 26.b4±

Black will have to defend an extremely unpleasant endgame.

C22) 10...♘a6



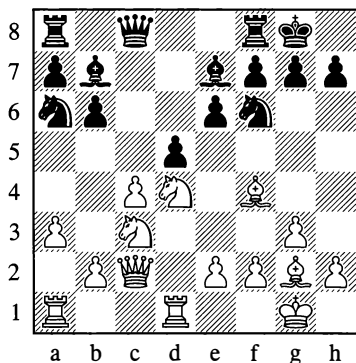
This has been played quite often by Tiviakov. I think White should take a moment to restrict the knight.

11.a3

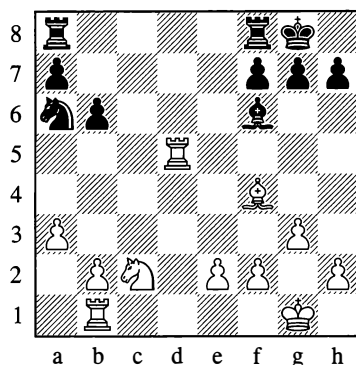
One of the points behind Black's last move can be seen after 11.♘c3 dxc4 12.♘e5 ♘d5 13.♘xc4 ♘xf4 14.gxf4 ♘b4! when the knight comes into play with tempo. 15.♙d2 ♘d5 Black had a decent position in V. Mikhalevski – Tiviakov, Hoogeveen 2000.

11...♙c8

Black is not ready to open the centre, as was clearly demonstrated in the following game: 11...c5 12.♘c3 cxd4?! 13.♘xd4 ♙c8 (The natural 13...♙c8 is met strongly by 14.cxd5 ♘xd5 15.♘db5!±)



14.cxd5 ♘xd5 15.♘xd5 ♙xd5 16.♙xd5 (16.♘c6N± was equally strong) 16...♙xc2 17.♘xc2 exd5 Now in V. Mikhalevski – Vasovski, Ohrid 2001, White could have simply grabbed the pawn with 18.♙xd5N ♙f6 19.♙b1.

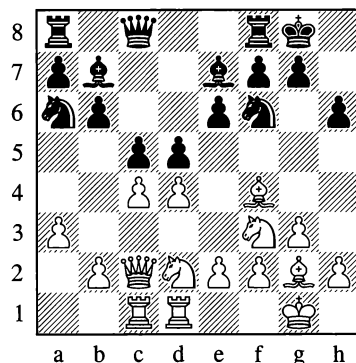


Black has no compensation.

11...♙c8 12.♘bd2 c5 13.♙ac1 h6

Pawn exchanges do not solve Black's problems: 13...dxc4N 14.♙xc4 ♘d5 15.dxc5 ♘xc5 16.b4 ♘d7 17.♙b3 ♙d8 18.♘d4± White retains a lot of pressure.

This position occurred in Cordts – Graf, Bad Wiessee 2013. Here White could have obtained an advantage against his 2600-rated opponent as follows:



14.cxd5!N exd5

14...♙xd5 15.e4 ♙b7 16.dxc5 ♘xc5 17.♙b1 ♙e8 18.♘e5 ♙c8 19.b4 ♘a4 20.♘dc4 gives

White much the better game.

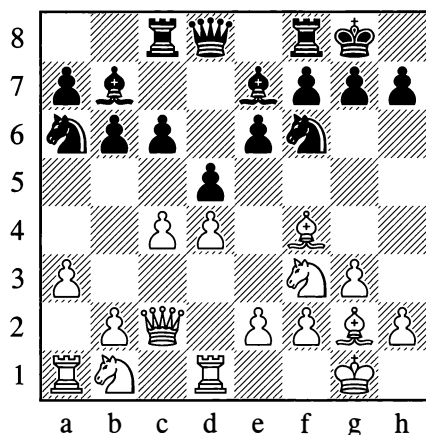
14...♘d5 15.♙e5 cxd4 16.♘c4! also clearly favours White.

15.dxc5 bxc5 16.♘b3 ♖d8

There is no better way for Black to stop ♘a5.

17.♖d2! ♘e4 18.♗e1

White will follow up with either ♘e5 or ♘a5, and his position looks clearly preferable.



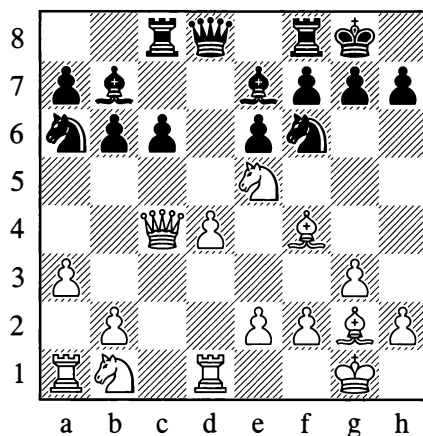
12.♘e5!

This is where I am diverging from *GM 1*.

12.♘c3 dxc4 13.♘e5 ♘d5 14.♘xc4 ♘xf4 15.gxf4 ♘c7 16.e3 ♘d5 transposes to a position mentioned in the next chapter, which I now prefer to avoid, for reasons explained on page 214 in the note to move 11.

12...dxc4 13.♗xc4!N

An obvious improvement over 13.♘c4 ♘d5 14.♘c3, which transposes to 12.♘c3 above.



13...♘d5 14.♘c3 ♘xf4 15.gxf4±

With the queen placed on c4 and the knight active on e5, White has a favourable version of this thematic pawn structure.

Conclusion

7...dxc4?! is a pointless move that leaves Black a tempo down compared to normal lines.

7...♘bd7 will usually transpose to the next chapter after a subsequent ...c6, but switching to a Stonewall set-up with ...♘e4 and ...f5 is an interesting alternative. White should keep the ♘fd2 idea in mind, intending to eliminate the strong knight and get active in the centre with f2-f3 and e2-e4.

7...c6 8.♗c2 b6 9.♙f4 is the most important branch of the chapter. Now 9...♙a6 looks active, but my new recommendation of 10.cxd5 cxd5 11.♗c1 is deceptively unpleasant for Black, as White often retains a nagging, risk-free advantage, even after multiple exchanges. 9...♙b7 is a bit more solid. I still like the white position after 10.♗d1, especially taking into account the new discoveries I have made since *GM 1* was published.